CODEX IN VS CODE

Complete beginner guide with exact places to click

Learn what Codex can do, exactly where to go in VS Code, what to ask, and how to check its work. Written in simple words for your phonics-games project.

You are in charge. Codex is a helper. Tell it what you want, look at its changes, and choose what to keep.

Quick map: where do I click?

- Open Codex: click its icon on the left. If missing: Ctrl+Shift+P → type “Codex: Open Codex Sidebar” → Enter.
- Open files: click Explorer on the left, or press Ctrl+Shift+E.
- Open Codex settings: Codex sidebar → gear → Codex Settings.
- Open VS Code settings: press Ctrl+, → search `@ext:openai.chatgpt`.
- See file changes: Source Control icon on the left, or Ctrl+Shift+G.
- Open the terminal: Ctrl+` (the key under Esc).
- Open the Command Palette: Ctrl+Shift+P.
- Preview a game: Explorer → right-click its HTML file → Open with Live Server.

These shortcuts are for Windows. Menu names can change a little between versions. If a button is missing, press Ctrl+Shift+P and search for its name.

1. Open Codex and ask your first question

1. Open VS Code. Choose File → Open Folder… and open phonics-games.
2. Click the Codex icon on the left. If you cannot see it, press Ctrl+Shift+P, type “Codex: Open Codex Sidebar”, and press Enter.
3. Click the message box at the bottom of the Codex panel.
4. Type your question and press Enter.

```
Explain templates/P-pic-word.html in simple words.
Do not edit. Tell me how it starts, checks an answer,
and moves to the next word.
```

Codex can explain, find, plan, build, fix, review, and help you learn. It can work with HTML (page parts), CSS (how it looks), JavaScript (how it acts), JSON (saved data), and text. It may run commands if your settings let it.

2. Give Codex the right file

1. Click Explorer on the left (or press Ctrl+Shift+E).
2. Click folders to open them, for example templates → P-pic-word.html.
3. Click the file to open it. Drag over lines if you want to ask about a small part.
4. Click Codex’s message box. If it offers to add the open file or selected lines, choose that. Otherwise, type the file name in your request.

```
Find where the Challenge 1 tile gets its game-page link.
Show me the file and code that controls it. Do not edit.
```

For a bug, tell Codex what you clicked, what you expected, what happened, and paste the browser error if there is one.

3. Ask for a plan or a change

Say whether you want an answer only, a plan, or an edit. For bigger tasks, ask for the plan first.

Plan first

```
I want children to choose easy or hard words. Find how the
game picks words. List files that might change and suggest
a plan. Do not edit yet.
```

Then build it

```
That plan looks good. Make the change. Keep the current
word list and screen style. Done means a child can choose a
level and the game uses words from that level.
```

Say exactly what you want

```
Goal: Add a replay button to the picture-word game.
Where: templates/P-pic-word.html
Rules: Replay starts a fresh round and resets score/progress.
Keep the existing word list.
Done when: I can finish and replay with a clean score.
```

For ideas only, say: “Give me three ideas. Do not edit.” You do not need coding words. Describe what a child should be able to do.

4. Work with Codex in the editor

- Ask about selected code: open a file → select lines → go to the Codex box → ask what those lines do.
- Ask where a feature lives: name the button, sound, word, or screen and say “find it; do not edit.”
- Ask a follow-up: type it into the same chat, such as “Keep the sound button; your change removed it.”
- Ask for a correction: describe the part that is wrong and the result you want instead.

For a hard bug: open the page, repeat the steps that cause it, copy any error from the browser Console (often F12 → Console), and send the steps plus error to Codex.

5. Look at what Codex changed

The change view is called a diff. It shows lines that were added, changed, or removed.

1. Read Codex’s summary in the chat.
2. Click a changed file or diff card/link in the summary.
3. Read the marked lines. Check that the right files changed and your rules were followed.
4. Ask questions in the same chat. To ask for a separate bug review, click the Codex box, type `/review`, choose it from the menu, and press Enter.
5. Keep or undo changes using the diff controls or VS Code Undo. Check Source Control first so you do not undo your own earlier work.

```
Explain this diff in simple words. Did you change
anything that affects a different game?
```

6. Preview and check your activity

1. Save the HTML file with Ctrl+S.
2. In Explorer, right-click the HTML file.
3. Choose “Open with Live Server”. If missing, press Ctrl+Shift+P and search “Live Server: Open with Live Server”. Live Server must be installed.
4. In the browser, try Start, right and wrong answers, the last question, replay, sound, and a narrow phone-sized window.
5. Tell Codex the exact steps if something fails. Ask it what it checked itself and what you still need to try.

This project sets Live Server to port 5501 in `.vscode/settings.json`.

7. Set project preferences and Codex settings

Change project rules in AGENTS.md

1. In Explorer, click AGENTS.md at the top of the project.
2. Add a short rule you want Codex to remember for this project.
3. Press Ctrl+S.
4. Ask Codex: “Read AGENTS.md and tell me the rules you will follow.”

Your file already says to make playful learning activities for young children, support phones and touch, follow each page’s style, reuse lesson data, and use Ghanaian examples when they fit.

Change Codex settings

1. Click the gear in the Codex sidebar.
2. Choose Codex Settings.
3. Choose an area such as model, reasoning, permissions, or personal preferences.
4. Choose Open config.toml only for advanced settings.

Change VS Code extension settings

1. Press Ctrl+, .
2. Search `@ext:openai.chatgpt` or `Codex`.
3. Change the editor option you need.

Codex settings are shared with the Codex command-line tool. VS Code options control how the extension behaves. Live Server port 5501 is separate.

8. Use shortcut commands in the Codex box

Click the Codex message box and type `/`. A menu shows commands available to you. Choose one and press Enter. Some commands may not be in every version.

- `/plan` — plan a multi-step task.
- `/review` — review changes for bugs.
- `/model` — choose the AI model, if shown.
- `/reasoning` — change thinking effort, if shown.
- `/permissions` — change what Codex can do, if shown.
- `/ide-context` — control use of open files, if shown.
- `/mcp` — view connected tool servers, if shown.

9. Save a Git checkpoint

1. Press Ctrl+Shift+G or click Source Control on the left.
2. Click changed files to inspect their diffs.
3. To save a checkpoint, type a short message (example: “Add replay button”) in the message box and click Commit.
4. If asked to stage files, read the file list and stage only the changes you mean to save.

A commit saves changes in project history. Do not commit just because Codex says so. Be careful with commands that erase or replace work.

10. Commands and permissions

The terminal is where commands run. Open it with Ctrl+` or the top menu Terminal → New Terminal. Read a command before allowing Codex to run it.

- Ask what it does if you are unsure.

- Be extra careful with commands that delete files, install programs, change many files, or use the internet.
- Give Codex only the access needed for this job.
- A sandbox is a fence that limits what Codex can reach. Permission choices are in Codex Settings.

```
Before running that command, explain what it does,
which files it changes, and whether it uses the internet.
```

11. Other useful jobs

Learn

“Explain this code in simple words.”

Find

“Find where the word list is loaded.”

Design

“Give me three screen ideas. Do not edit.”

Build

“Make a large answer button that is easy to tap.”

Content

“Suggest easy Grade 1 words with the sh sound.”

Instructions

“Write How to Play steps for a 7-year-old.”

Fix

“This button does nothing. Trace and fix the cause.”

Review

“Look for bugs in these changes. Do not edit.”

12. Skills, MCP, cloud, and helpers

Skills are saved how-to guides. In the Codex box, type `$` to see skills if your setup has them. Use only skills you trust.

MCP connects Codex to another tool or information source. Open Codex gear → Codex Settings → MCP Servers (label may differ) to find connections. `/mcp` may show their status. Check what a connection can access.

Some setups offer longer cloud tasks or other helper agents. Use them for bigger separate work. Still review every final change. For a small change, keep Codex beside your code in VS Code.

13. Full example: build a phonics game

1. Open a similar activity in Explorer. Ask Codex to find its word data and explain what can be reused. Say “Do not edit yet.”
2. After you read the plan, ask it to build a Grade 1 “sh” sound game. Explain that a child hears a word, picks one of three answers, gets friendly feedback, and can replay.
3. Say what finished means: sound works, answers work, next word loads, replay resets, phone layout fits.
4. Read the summary and diff. Make sure it uses the right word data and does not change an unrelated game.
5. Right-click the new HTML file → Open with Live Server. Try correct and wrong answers, sound, the last word, replay, and a narrow screen.
6. Report exact problems to Codex and check again after the fix.

14. Prompt cards

Explain

```
Explain [file/part] in simple words. Do not edit.
```

Find

```
Find where [button/word/rule] is controlled. Do not edit.
```

Plan

```
I want [goal]. List files and steps. Do not edit yet.
```

Build

```
Make [goal] in [place]. Keep [things]. Done means [result].
```

Fix

```
I expected [A], but [B] happened after [steps]. Find and fix it.
```

Review

```
Review current changes for bugs. Do not edit.
```

Check

```
Tell me what you checked and what I should try.
```

Teach

```
Explain why it works and define new words.
```

15. If you get stuck

Wrong file

Name the right file. Ask Codex to undo only its unrelated edit. Check the diff.

Too hard to understand

Ask for three short steps in easy words.

Still broken

Give the exact steps, expected result, actual result, and error.

Too many edits

Ask for the smallest change that still works.

Too much work at once

Ask for a status and do one small part at a time.

Your routine: Check existing edits → ask clearly → plan big work → inspect the diff → try it in the browser → save good work with Git. Use everyday words; you do not need to be a coding expert.

Official guides

Codex in VS Code — https://learn.chatgpt.com/docs/codex/ide

AGENTS.md instructions — https://learn.chatgpt.com/docs/agent-configuration/agents-md

Developer settings — https://learn.chatgpt.com/docs/developer-settings

Permissions — https://learn.chatgpt.com/docs/permission-modes

Skills — https://learn.chatgpt.com/docs/build-skills

Slash commands — https://learn.chatgpt.com/docs/reference/slash-commands

OpenAI Docs MCP — https://learn.chatgpt.com/learn/docs-mcp

Button labels and available tools can change with your version and account. If something looks different, search the Command Palette or click the Codex gear.